

STAGE NINE • ENGLISH VOCABULARY FIRST SET

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Nine • English Vocabulary First Set

PURPOSE

Stage Nine is fundamentally different from most other stages in this program: it's vocabulary instruction, not reflection or personal-action exercises. That changes what “group adaptation” means here. Instead of pair shares and outside perspective, this stage's group versions are drills, games, and live-production exercises — the kinds of activities a language class uses to convert passive recognition into genuine, usable fluency.

This document adapts ten FIRSTS across all six sections into circle drills, relay exercises, mock simulations, and games. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants review or study each vocabulary set individually first, and the group version tests whether it's actually become usable under real, live conditions.

A theme worth naming explicitly: nearly every one of these exercises works because it forces real-time, unscripted production. Vocabulary that only survives in a prepared sentence written in advance hasn't yet become genuinely fluent — these exercises are designed to expose that gap live, in a low-stakes way.

The Ten Adapted Exercises

FIRST M1

20 Professional Adjectives Learned — Circle Association Drill

TIME: +10 min beyond solo study

1. In a circle, facilitator says one adjective from the list.
2. Going around, each person must use that adjective in a new, genuine sentence about a real person they know (with permission implied, no names required).
3. Rotate to a new adjective every 3–4 people, cycling through as much of the list as time allows.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Hearing the same word used in many different genuine sentences, back to back, builds far more real flexibility with a word than a single individual example does.

FIRST M5

20 Workplace Phrases for Communication — Email Dictation Relay

TIME: +15 min beyond solo review

1. Pairs. Partner A is given a short, informal message (facilitator-prepared) and must “translate” it out loud into professional workplace phrasing in real time.
2. Partner B writes down what they hear as Partner A speaks.
3. Compare the written result against the original informal message, and discuss what changed.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Real-time verbal translation is harder and more revealing than written practice alone — it exposes which phrases are genuinely internalized versus only recognized on the page.

FIRST M9

10 Common Academic/Business Idioms — Idiom Matching Game

TIME: +15 min beyond solo review

1. Prepare two sets of cards: one with each idiom, one with a plain-language explanation of its meaning.
2. In small groups, race to correctly match every idiom to its meaning.
3. First group done calls it out; review any genuine mismatches together as a full group.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A game format lowers the stakes around idioms specifically, since getting one “wrong” in a matching game feels very different from misusing one in a real conversation.

FIRST M16

Meeting/Call Vocabulary — Fishbowl Meeting Simulation

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. 4–5 volunteers hold a short mock meeting (facilitator provides a simple topic) in the center of the room.
2. Volunteers must use at least three phrases from this list naturally during the conversation.
3. Observers listen specifically for correct, natural use versus forced or awkward insertion, and debrief afterward.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Using this vocabulary inside a genuinely flowing conversation, not an isolated drill, is the real test of whether it's become usable rather than just memorized.

FIRST M17

Negotiation & Persuasion Vocabulary — Mock Negotiation

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Give each side a simple, opposing goal (facilitator-prepared: e.g., one wants a later deadline, one needs it on time).
2. Each side must use at least two phrases from this list while negotiating toward a real resolution.
3. Debrief: did the negotiation reach a genuine, fair resolution, or did one side just concede?

FACILITATOR NOTE

A real opposing-goals setup forces genuine use of persuasive, collaborative language under actual (if low-stakes) pressure, rather than in a vacuum.

FIRST M24

Question-Asking Vocabulary — Hot Seat

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drill

1. One volunteer sits in the “hot seat” and briefly describes a real project or experience.
2. The group takes turns asking only genuinely open-ended questions about it, using this list's vocabulary.
3. If a question is actually closed (answerable in one word), the group calls it out and the asker rephrases it live.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Live, real-time correction of a closed question into an open one builds the skill far faster than reviewing examples on paper alone.

FIRST M26

Presentation Introduction Vocabulary — Rapid-Fire Openers

TIME: +15 min beyond solo practice

1. Each participant delivers just their presentation opener (not a full presentation) to the group, one after another, no more than 20 seconds each.

2. After every three openers, pause for the group to name what made the strongest one land.
3. Second round: same participants, same topic, revised openers based on what was just discussed.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Hearing many openers back to back, with a genuine group debrief in between rounds, builds a much sharper ear for what “confident opening language” actually sounds like than a single individual attempt.

FIRST M30

Q&A Handling Vocabulary — Surprise Question Gauntlet

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. One volunteer briefly presents on any familiar topic for one minute.
2. The group fires 3–4 rapid, genuinely challenging or unexpected questions, including at least one they likely can't fully answer.
3. Volunteer practices this list's graceful-acknowledgment language live, rather than bluffing.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The instinct to bluff is strongest under genuine surprise and mild social pressure — a scripted, expected question doesn't create the same real test this vocabulary is meant for.

FIRST M36

Vocabulary for Brainstorming and Ideation Sessions — Live Generative Round

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Small groups. Facilitator gives one genuine, open prompt (e.g., “ways to make onboarding less boring”).
2. For 3 minutes, the group must generate ideas using only this list's generative language — any evaluative comment (“that won't work”) resets the group's idea count to zero.
3. Count and celebrate whichever group generated the most ideas without a reset.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The reset penalty makes the discipline of staying generative viscerally real, rather than just a rule stated and immediately forgotten under the pull of instinctive evaluation.

FIRST M37

Vocabulary for Reflecting on Personal Growth and Lessons Learned — Growth Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond solo writing

1. In a circle, each person shares their growth statement and specific example from the individual worksheet, one at a time.
2. After each share, one other person reflects back what specifically made the example concrete and convincing (or gently notes if it felt generic).
3. Continue until everyone has shared once.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This closes the entire stage on a genuinely reflective, connective note, and the peer feedback on specificity reinforces the exact skill M37 is teaching: examples carry the weight, not the growth language alone.